

their parents' computers for a double date in the Metaverse, climbing down out of Port Zero, which is the local port of entry and monorail stop. He is not seeing real people, of course. This is all a part of the moving illustration drawn by his computer according to specifications coming down the fiber-optic cable. The people are pieces of software called avatars. They are the audiovisual bodies that people use to communicate with each other in the Metaverse."

Stephenson's "Metaverse" is, of course, the Internet. Specifically, the part of the Net that hosts virtual life.

Still, as far as we know, no-one predicted the magnitude of the speeds we have today on our undersea cables—or the volume of the traffic—or even that they would be under the sea. Sci-Fa.

Artificial Idiots

It's time we quoted Arthur C Clarke, an SF god. Here's from *The City and the Stars*, 1956: "...the all-but-infinite intellect of the Central Computer. It was difficult not to think of the Central Computer as a living entity, localized in a single spot, though actually it was the sum total of all of the machines in Diaspar. Even if it was not alive in the biological sense, it certainly possessed at least as much awareness and self-consciousness as a human being." Primitive, simplistic, almost child-like.

But then here's from *Ralph 124c 41 +*, by Hugo Gernsback, 1911, in relation to voice recognition: "...she called out sharply: 'Lux!' The delicate detecophone mechanism of the Luminor responded instantly to her command; the room was flooded

at once with the beautiful cold pink-white Luminor light..." 1911 for voice recognition is prodigious indeed. But we're still at 99.8% accuracy or thereabouts, and that's the theoretical figure—and remember, 99.8 is very different from 99.9 is different from 99.99. Sad.

Let's cease and desist. They imagined what was to come; it turned out to be harder than anyone had imagined; and it didn't come.

Nobel Laureate Herbert Simon, an authority on AI and a pioneer in the field, said that by 1985, machines would be capable of doing any work a man could do. KRASH, KA-BOOM, and PLONK are the sounds of that ludicrously optimistic prediction falling flat—nuff said. Sci-Fa—not.

So Where's My Flying Car?

Way too many people ask that in sarcastic tones without looking up the facts. The Flying Car—as in everyday transportation, with no runway or airstrip required—happens to be a staple of way too many sci-fi novels. So where's your flying car? In Massachusetts.

2009 will be the year, if you can believe a company that will take 5 per cent of the cost of their flying car right now by credit card as a booking deposit. That company is Terrafugia (figure the URL—and no prizes). They are "roadable aircraft"

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